Why are Christian video games deemed preachy?

Case Studies Into the Formal Elements of Christian Entertainment Software and How They Affect Player Engagement.

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A dissertation submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the degree of M.Sc. in Digital Games.

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First edition, Tuesday 3rd March, 2026

To John Doe

Some more descriptive text.

Acknowledgements

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Abstract

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Contents

List of Abbreviations **x**

1 Introduction **1**
1.1 Motivation 1
1.2 Aims and Objectives 1
1.3 Our Approach 1
1.4 Document Structure 2

2 Background & Literature Overview **3**
2.1 What are Christian Video Games? 3
2.2 Related Work 4
2.3 Summary 4

3 Materials & Methods **5**
3.1 Summary 5

4 Results & Discussion **6**
4.1 Summary 6

5 Conclusions **7**
5.1 Revisiting the Aims and Objectives 7
5.2 Critique and Limitations 7
5.3 Future Work 8
5.4 Final Remarks 8

Appendix A Media Content **9**

Appendix B Installation Instructions **10**

Appendix C User Manual **11**

References **12**
Ludography 12

List of Figures

List of Tables

List of Abbreviations

1

Introduction

1.1 | Motivation

1.2 | Aims and Objectives

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1.3 | Our Approach

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1.4 | Document Structure

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2

Background & Literature Overview

2.1 | What are Christian Video Games?

In an interview, games scholar Kevin Schut states that currently, there is no consensus on what defines a Christian game (Faith Forms, 2024, 8:38). This becomes apparent when one examines online discussion around the topic. For example, one of the factors that Moon Channel (2023) considers when determining if a video game is Christian is that it must promote Christian morals. Meanwhile, Hartgrove (2022) considers *Hypnospace Outlaw* (2019) a Christian game simply because its creator, Jay Tholen, identifies as a Christian[1]. Within the same interview, Schut also seems to imply that the definition is subject to change, given that the use of the label is undergoing constant cultural negotiation (08:50, 24:26). Therefore, before conducting my study, I needed to establish a working definition of "Christian video games".

Earlier work by Schut (2013) gives us a good starting point for such a definition. Based on a series of interviews with seventeen Christians working in the game industry, he outlined four definitions of "Christian Games". Explicitly Christian Games "feature Bible stories or passages, very clear presentation of the gospel message, and stories that very openly have a Christian worldview". As an example, Schut raises *Big Bible Town* (2010), a video game which aims to teach children about Bible stories. Meanwhile, Allegorical Christian Games "have stories that are not necessarily openly Christian but have Christian themes or messages underneath them" (p. 137). Interviewees mentioned no instances of such games, but they cited the Narnia series by C.S. Lewis as an example of this style.

Interviewees also raised what Schut terms as Evangelical Christian video games,

[1] Although he does discuss the game's content somewhat, he mainly focuses on how Jay Tholen's beliefs are reflected within the game. Hartgrove does not deem explicit ideological content as necessary, however.

which "focus on sharing the gospel with people who aren't Christians". (pp. 137–138). However, this is only a hypothetical definition since Schut could not cite an examples. Lastly, Christian-friendly games, such as Bejeweled and Words With Friends, are "clean and safe, without significant violence, adult sexuality, swearing, anti-Christian worldviews, and other things that Christians might find offensive or disturbing" (p. 137).

Schut's work also gives valuable insight into how the term "Christian Games" is used. For example, he notes that most of the interviewees commonly defined "Christian Games" as either Explicitly Christian Games or Allegorically Christian games. However, only few of them considered Christian-friendly games part of the genre. Based on these observations I could have based my definition on the most common uses of the term. However, there was one issue which made me hesitant to do so — the ambiguous use of the term "Christian".

While the distinction between "Christian" and "non-Christian" outlooks or morals may seem trivial, there have been disagreements in the past. For example, Gonzalez (2014) talks about *The War In Heaven*, a first-person shooter which has been criticised for allowing players to play as demons. She points out an anonymous review in which the reviewer argues that the game does not teach the Bible in the right context (p. 209). Nevertheless, the developers defended this inclusion, stating that "[their] design is in accordance with Biblical teachings" (p. 204).

2.2 | Related Work

2.3 | Summary

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3

Materials & Methods

This section should include a recipe of what you did (explain what you have done so if someone wants to reproduce the experiment, they can). Should also include a description of statistical methods used (if any).[1]

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3.1 | Summary

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[1]For more information see: `http://rc.rcjournal.com/content/49/10/1229.short`. Last Accessed: 27th November, 2024.

4

Results & Discussion

Should include a reiteration of the experiments, and their outcome. Together with a description (discussion). Preamble should include a reminder of the aims and objectives together with a list of experiments to achieve these. Should include many charts and other visualization with appropriate descriptions.[1]

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4.1 | Summary

[1] Another footnote example.

5

Conclusions

This section should have a summary of the whole project. The original aims and objective and whether these have been met should be discussed. It should include a section with a critique and a list of limitations of your proposed solutions. Future work should be described, and this should not be marginal or silly (e.g. add machine learning models). It is always good to end on a positive note (i.e. 'Final Remarks').

5.1 | Revisiting the Aims and Objectives

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5.2 | Critique and Limitations

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5.3 | Future Work

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5.4 | Final Remarks

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A

Media Content

If the dissertation has a DVD or pendrive attached to it, you will need a section which explains what is on the media (structure, files, data, etc.). This could be a table with filename and description.

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B

Installation Instructions

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C

User Manual

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Ludography

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